Unit -1

Vijayanagar and Bahmani Kingdoms



Learning Objectives

- To know the circumstances that led to the rise and expansion of Vijayanagar and Bahmani kingdoms
- To familiarise ourselves with the administration, military organisation and the economic life during the time of their reign
- To know the contribution of Vijayanagar and Bahmani rulers to literature art and architecture

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Introduction

The political condition of India in the fourteenth century provided great opportunities for the rise of new kingdoms in the south. The repressive measures of the temperamental Muslim king Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq led to the rise of many new independent states. In the south, Vijayanagar and Gulbarga or Bahmani emerged as two great kingdoms. The Bahmani kingdom spread all over the Maharashtra region and partly over Karnataka. Ruled by 18 monarchs, it lasted for nearly 180 years. Early in the sixteenth century, it collapsed and split into five sultanates – Bijapur, Ahmednagar, Golconda, Bidar and Berar. The state of Vijayanagar continued to flourish for nearly 200 years. Ultimately Vijayanagar's wealth and prosperity induced the Muslim Deccan kingdoms to launch a combined war against it. In 1565, the battle of Talikota, finally they could succeed in crushing Vijayanagar Empire.

Foundation of Vijayanagar Empire

Vijayanagara, the 'city of victory', was established in southern Karnataka by two brothers named Harihara and Bukka. According to one tradition, Vidyaranya, head of the Saivite Sringeri mutt, instructed them to abandon their service to the Tughluqs and rescue the country from Muslim authority. The new kingdom was called Vidyanagara for a time in honour of the spiritual teacher Vidyaranya, before it came to be called Vijayanagara. Four dynasties, namely

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